

The Japanese Tea Ceremony

Chado — The Way of Tea

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Contents

1	Introduction	1
2	Historical Origins	1
2.1	The Influence of Zen Buddhism	1
2.2	Sen no Rikyu	1
3	The Tearoom and Garden	1
3.1	The Roji Garden	1
3.2	The Tearoom	1
3.3	The Nijiriguchi	1
4	Utensils of the Ceremony	2
4.1	Chawan — the Tea Bowl	2
4.2	Chakin — the Tea Cloth	2
4.3	Chasen — the Tea Whisk	2
4.4	Chashaku — the Tea Scoop	2
5	The Ceremony Itself	2
5.1	Preparation and Arrival	2
5.2	The Making of Tea	2
5.3	Receiving the Bowl	2
6	Aesthetics: Wabi and Sabi	2
7	Conclusion	3
8	A Small Story	3

Abstract

This document explores *chado*, or the Way of Tea — the Japanese art of preparing and sharing powdered green tea, *matcha*, in a ritual context rooted in Zen Buddhism, aesthetics, and mindful hospitality. From the humble tearoom to the precise movements of the host, the tea ceremony is a discipline of presence and grace that has shaped Japanese culture for over five centuries.

1 Introduction

In Japan, the act of drinking tea is not merely a matter of refreshment. It is a philosophy made physical. The tea ceremony — *chanoyu* (“hot water for tea”) or *chado* (“the way of tea”) — transforms the preparation and sharing of a bowl of *matcha* into an art form guided by four principles first articulated by the tea master Sen no Rikyu in the sixteenth century: *wa* (harmony), *kei* (respect), *sei* (purity), and *jaku* (tranquility).

2 Historical Origins

Tea was brought to Japan from China by Buddhist monks in the ninth century, but it was not until the twelfth century that powdered *matcha* became widespread, introduced by the monk Eisai who planted tea seeds at Kyoto’s Ryoanji temple. Over the following centuries, the drinking of tea evolved from a courtly pastime into a refined spiritual and aesthetic practice.

2.1 The Influence of Zen Buddhism

The tea ceremony is inseparable from Zen. The tearoom is a space of deliberate simplicity where rank and status are left at the door. The very act of entering — through a small, low entrance called the *nijiriguchi* that requires every guest to bow, whether peasant or samurai — embodies this egalitarianism.

2.2 Sen no Rikyu

The most influential figure in the history of the tea ceremony was Sen no Rikyu (1522–1591), tea master to the warlords Oda Nobunaga and Toyotomi Hideyoshi. Rikyu refined the aesthetic of *wabi-cha* — a style that prized rustic simplicity, asymmetry, and imperfection over courtly splendour. His vision defined the practice for all subsequent generations.

3 The Tearoom and Garden

The physical setting of the tea ceremony is designed as carefully as the ceremony itself. Every element — from the garden path to the hanging scroll — contributes to the aesthetic and spiritual intention of the gathering.

3.1 The Roji Garden

Guests approach the tearoom through a *roji*, a dewy garden path of stepping stones, moss, and carefully placed lanterns. The walk through the garden is itself a transition: a gradual leaving behind of the everyday world and an entry into the time and space of tea.

3.2 The Tearoom

Traditional tearooms (*chashitsu*) are small — often only four and a half tatami mats in area. The walls are of earthen plaster, the ceiling of bamboo or wood, the tokonoma (alcove) hung with a calligraphy scroll and set with a single seasonal flower arrangement. Nothing is accidental; nothing is excessive.

3.3 The Nijiriguchi

The small crawling entrance is one of the most famous features of the traditional tearoom. Approximately 66 centimetres square, it compels every guest to kneel and bow in order to enter, regardless of their social standing. It is an architectural expression of equality and humility.

4 Utensils of the Ceremony

The objects used in the tea ceremony are among the most treasured artefacts in Japanese material culture. Chosen with great care, they are often centuries old, bearing the marks of use as signs of beauty rather than wear.

4.1 Chawan — the Tea Bowl

The *chawan* is the central object of the ceremony. Raku ware bowls — hand-shaped rather than wheel-thrown, fired at low temperatures — are among the most prized, valued precisely for their irregular forms and subtle imperfections. The guest turns the bowl before drinking to avoid placing the lips on its “front”.

4.2 Chakin — the Tea Cloth

The *chakin* is a small rectangular cloth of white linen used to wipe the tea bowl. Its folding and use follow a precise sequence, and even the act of setting it down is deliberate. It is changed for each gathering and must be immaculately clean.

4.3 Chasen — the Tea Whisk

Carved from a single piece of bamboo into dozens of fine tines, the *chasen* is used to whisk the powdered *matcha* with hot water into a smooth, frothy liquid. It is one of the most technically demanding objects in the ceremony to produce, requiring the skill of specialist craftspeople.

4.4 Chashaku — the Tea Scoop

The *chashaku* is a slender bamboo scoop used to measure powdered tea from its container into the bowl. Masters carve their own scoops and give them poetic names, and a named scoop by a celebrated master is a treasured object in its own right.

5 The Ceremony Itself

The sequence of a full tea ceremony (*chaji*) can last up to four hours, encompassing a meal, a short break in the garden, and both a thick tea (*koicha*) and a thin tea (*usucha*) service. The abbreviated version (*chakai*) focuses on the thin tea service and is more commonly encountered today.

5.1 Preparation and Arrival

The host prepares the tearoom for hours before the guests arrive, cleaning every surface, arranging the charcoal, selecting the scroll and the flower, and drawing water. Guests arrive quietly, inspect the garden and the tearoom’s alcove in silence, and take their places on the tatami.

5.2 The Making of Tea

Every movement the host makes in preparing the tea has been refined over centuries into a sequence of precise and beautiful gestures. The wiping of the bowl, the measuring of the tea, the ladling of the water, the whisking — each action is performed with full attention, as if it were both ordinary and sacred, which is precisely what it is.

5.3 Receiving the Bowl

A guest receives the bowl with both hands, bows to the host, turns the bowl clockwise twice to avoid drinking from its face, drinks in three and a half sips, wipes the rim, and turns the bowl back before returning it. Every motion is a form of gratitude.

6 Aesthetics: Wabi and Sabi

At the heart of the tea ceremony’s aesthetic philosophy are two intertwined concepts: *wabi*, the beauty of simplicity and rusticity, and *sabi*, the beauty of age, impermanence, and transience. A cracked tea bowl repaired with gold lacquer (*kintsugi*), a garden moss grown over decades, a scroll chosen for the exact season of this one afternoon — these embody an acceptance of impermanence that is also a form of celebration.

7 Conclusion

The Japanese tea ceremony is a practice of extraordinary refinement that asks very little of the world — a small room, a bowl of tea, a few quiet guests — and finds in those small things a complete philosophy. To study *chado* is to study attention itself: the art of being fully present in a single act, repeated with care, for a lifetime.

8 A Small Story

*The water in the iron kettle sang
a low, continuous note, like wind through pines.
She wiped the bowl and heard the way it rang
against the silence, reading its designs.
The scroll said only: one time, one meeting.
Ichi-go, ichi-e — she knew it well.
This gathering would have no repeating,
no second chance to set the bowl, to tell
the guest how much the afternoon had meant.
So every gesture held its full weight:
the scoop, the whisk, the bow, the water spent
in steam that rose and vanished at the grate.
She set the bowl before him without a word.
He turned it twice. Outside, a single bird.*

Secrets

Here are the secrets to the typesetting of this document:

- Paper size is A4
- Margin is 0.70 inches all around
- Font size is 11pt
- ETbb is set as the body font for its clean, bookish elegance
- multicol package with 20pt column separation is used for the four utensil subsections
- Do not forget to use hyperref
- ragged2e contributed to the right-aligned “A Small Story” section
- The page background and text colors use the xcolor package. Custom color names are defined with `\definecolor` by giving a name and three RGB numbers (0–255 for red, green, blue). Then `\pagecolor{}` fills the whole page and `\color{}` sets the text color. The colors used here are:

```
\definecolor{RiceWhite}{RGB}{248, 244, 232}  
\definecolor{InkBlack}{RGB}{28, 38, 28}  
\definecolor{BambooGreen}{RGB}{74, 115, 68}  
\definecolor{MossGreen}{RGB}{130, 160, 100}  
\definecolor{MatchaDeep}{RGB}{52, 88, 46}  
  
\pagecolor{RiceWhite}  
\color{InkBlack}
```

- The page border frame is achieved by using the tikz and eso-pic packages and then adding the following snippet in the preamble after the color definitions. `\AddToShipoutPictureBG` repeats the drawing on every page. Inside, `remember picture`, `overlay` lets TikZ position things relative to the physical page

corners. Each `\draw` command traces a rectangle from one page corner to the opposite, nudged inward with `xshift` and `yshift`. Two rectangles with different offsets and line widths produce the outer-thick, inner-thin double border:

```
\AddToShipoutPictureBG{%
  \begin{tikzpicture}[remember picture, overlay]
    % Outer bold rectangle
    \draw[color=BambooGreen, line width=2.0pt]
      ([xshift=0.30cm, yshift=-0.30cm] current page.north west)
      rectangle
      ([xshift=-0.30cm, yshift=0.30cm] current page.south east);
    % Inner thin rectangle
    \draw[color=MossGreen, line width=0.6pt]
      ([xshift=0.48cm, yshift=-0.48cm] current page.north west)
      rectangle
      ([xshift=-0.48cm, yshift=0.48cm] current page.south east);
    % Small square notches at each corner - top left
    \draw[color=BambooGreen, line width=1.0pt]
      ([xshift=0.30cm, yshift=-0.30cm] current page.north west)
      -- ([xshift=0.60cm, yshift=-0.30cm] current page.north west)
      -- ([xshift=0.60cm, yshift=-0.60cm] current page.north west);
    % top right
    \draw[color=BambooGreen, line width=1.0pt]
      ([xshift=-0.30cm, yshift=-0.30cm] current page.north east)
      -- ([xshift=-0.60cm, yshift=-0.30cm] current page.north east)
      -- ([xshift=-0.60cm, yshift=-0.60cm] current page.north east);
    % bottom left
    \draw[color=BambooGreen, line width=1.0pt]
      ([xshift=0.30cm, yshift=0.30cm] current page.south west)
      -- ([xshift=0.60cm, yshift=0.30cm] current page.south west)
      -- ([xshift=0.60cm, yshift=0.60cm] current page.south west);
    % bottom right
    \draw[color=BambooGreen, line width=1.0pt]
      ([xshift=-0.30cm, yshift=0.30cm] current page.south east)
      -- ([xshift=-0.60cm, yshift=0.30cm] current page.south east)
      -- ([xshift=-0.60cm, yshift=0.60cm] current page.south east);
    % Mid-side small diamond markers
    \node[color=BambooGreen, font=\small] at
      ([yshift=-0.30cm] current page.north) {$\diamond$};
    \node[color=BambooGreen, font=\small] at
      ([yshift=0.30cm] current page.south) {$\diamond$};
    \node[color=BambooGreen, font=\small] at
      ([xshift=0.30cm] current page.west) {$\diamond$};
    \node[color=BambooGreen, font=\small] at
      ([xshift=-0.30cm] current page.east) {$\diamond$};
  \end{tikzpicture}%
}
```

- The title uses `\textcolor{MatchaDeep}{...}` to apply the deep matcha accent to the main title text
- Try to figure out how the code-style or teletype fonts are written